
“The **feeling for him was one of love**, not of awe and dread.”

GENERAL LONG'S DESCRIPTION OF LEE'S RELATIONS WITH HIS MEN, C.1864

Robert Edward Lee cultivated the South's ideal image of a man who was courteous and honorable and of a leader who could win against overwhelming odds through superior fighting skill and spirit. In reality, his character was more complex than this suggests, and his military performance mixed. To Black Americans, he was primarily an enslaver of 189 people, who broke up families by renting out men, often to plantations hundreds of miles away.

Lee saw himself first and foremost as a Virginian. Son of Henry Lee, a hero of the Revolutionary War, he was born into a slaveholding family among the First Families of Virginia. Despite such privileges, his childhood was not an easy one. He was 11 when his father died, leaving the family in dire financial straits and threatening its status. Lee's marriage to Mary Custis later connected him indirectly with the lineage of George Washington, thus securing his place in Virginia's landed aristocracy.